

former application was a proprietary product but was purchased by Sun Microsystems in 1999 who, within a year of its purchase, made the source code of the application openly accessible making it an open source experiment in community development. The name ‘OpenOffice.org’ was a result of the open source direction of the product by Sun and achieved over 1 million downloads by 2001.

The Apache OpenOffice is built around the free-to-use model which doesn’t require payment from users for the software. This Apache 2.0 License allows users to make the most of the software without any strings attached, and makes OpenOffice legal to use for any purposes, including home, business, educational and public administrations use. There are also no limitations on the number of companies and computers that can install it.

The Apache OpenOffice brand is backed by a team of developers primarily from the IBM Lotus Symphony heritage, which is a melting pot of the best practices of corporate technical skills and the overarching goals of the open source movement. Variations of this governance model for application development can be seen in other products such as LibreOffice (discussed later in this chapter), as they’re being managed on different ideological strands. The priority here has been to keep the system as open and free as possible.

The Apache OpenOffice brand has achieved great success and reputation due to its “built from scratch” design, which makes it very stable and consistent. As a product, it functions at the same performance levels as proprietary software like Microsoft Office. The biggest advantage of the OpenOffice system is the quick service response in the face of glitches. Faults and bugs reported by users are soon addressed thanks to the vast community of developers. This process allows the enhancement and upgradation of the software to happen dynamically on the fly making it very responsive to the user’s needs and wants.

Working with OpenOffice

The user interface and design of the OpenOffice system is made with the user in mind and is considered extremely easy to learn and use. The workflow is intuitive and based around people’s experience with other office suites making exploring and learning its features extremely natural.

The office suite comes with the full bundle of applications: ‘Writer’ for word processing, ‘Calc’ for spreadsheets, ‘Impress’ for presentations, ‘Draw’ for graphic illustration design, ‘Base’ for database use and ‘Math’ which is an equations editors. All these applications are built with common